Summer Research Fellow — US Anti-Corruption Court Project

Website: https://oresoftware.github.io/us-anti-corruption-court-project/

Position: Research Fellow (Summer 2026) **Duration:** 10–12 weeks (flexible start between May and June until August) **Compensation:** $3,000–$5,000, depending on hours and scope **Location:** Remote **Program:** Georgetown Anti-Corruption Program **Eligibility:** Undergraduate or graduate students

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About the Project

The US Anti-Corruption Court (USACC) is a proposed citizen-initiated court focused on public corruption — particularly conduct that is blatant and harmful but structured to stay on the technical side of existing law. The project is in the design and simulation phase: we are building a public website, a formal whitepaper, and a mathematical simulation of the court's operations modeled as a queuing system controlled by a Markov Decision Process (MDP).

We are looking for a **curious, mathematically oriented student** to contribute across several workstreams this summer. This fellowship is designed to produce real, portfolio-worthy research outputs — and for graduate students, the work is well-suited to seed or develop a **PhD thesis** in computational social science, mechanism design, institutional economics, or applied mathematics.

What You'll Work On

Website Development

- Contribute to the project's public-facing website (Astro/HTML/CSS/TypeScript)
- Help build pages that communicate the court's design and simulation results to a non-technical audience

Whitepaper and Written Research

- Co-author and refine sections of the formal whitepaper — court design, historical precedent analysis, and the MDP specification
- Research historical anti-corruption institutions and extract structural lessons for the court's design

Mathematical Modeling

- Work with the existing MDP formulation: state spaces, action spaces, reward structures, and policy evaluation for the court's multi-stage case-flow system
- Contribute to the discrete-event simulation (agent-based modeling of cases, judges, and sponsors)
- Explore policy evaluation, counterfactual analysis, and stress-testing

Corruption Taxonomy

- Help develop a rigorous taxonomy of corruption patterns — regulatory capture, pension self-dealing, patent-system abuse, revolving-door rewards, insider dealing, procurement steering, and others
- Classify archetypes along dimensions of detectability, evidence availability, diffuseness of harm, and amenability to non-criminal remedy
- Contribute to the court's living case-study catalog

Academic Program Development

- Research and propose new university programs in corruption studies — potential curricula, certificate programs, or interdisciplinary concentrations
- Survey existing academic offerings and identify gaps

Programming and Simulation

- Write simulation code (TypeScript) for the court's discrete-event engine
- Build tooling for policy comparison, scenario analysis, and visualization

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Who We're Looking For

- Strong mathematical foundation — comfort with probability, stochastic processes, and optimization. Familiarity with Markov models and Markov Decision Processes or reinforcement learning is a plus but not required
- Solid writing skills — you'll contribute to a whitepaper and public-facing materials
- Programming experience (TypeScript/JavaScript, Python, or similar) is helpful
- Intellectual curiosity about institutions, governance, and how systems fail

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Thesis Potential

For graduate students considering a PhD, this project offers a rich research surface. The intersection of simulation and controls, mechanism design, and institutional anti-corruption policy is largely unexplored in the academic literature. Summer work here can directly produce the modeling framework, simulation results, and empirical corruption taxonomy that form the foundation of a dissertation. We are happy to collaborate with your advisor on scoping.

Compensation and Logistics

- **Pay:** \$3,000–\$5,000 for the summer (~10–20 hours/week). Compatible with other summer commitments.
- **Format:** Fully remote. Weekly syncs, async collaboration via GitHub.
- **Deliverables:** Published website contributions, named sections of the whitepaper, simulation code, and/or a research memo on corruption taxonomy or program design.

- **Credit:** Contributions acknowledged by name in all published materials. Academic credit can be arranged with your program.